



Hamish the Highland Cow

A shaggy, sturdy Highland cow with a flattened brow, a wide cream muzzle and a weather-beaten fringe

Design Code NS 01

US terms

Intermediate

6-8 hours

Stitch counts verified

About 15 cm (6 in) sitting • 70 mm wide body • 70 x 67 mm head • worsted/aran on a 3.5 mm hook
Yarn A ginger ~25 g • Yarn B oat cream ~12 g • Yarn C dark chocolate ~5 g • optional rust scarf •
2 x 12 mm safety eyes

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SAFETY — READ THIS FIRST

Hamish has two 12 mm safety eyes — small parts. Lock the washers firmly from the inside (this pattern locks them after the muzzle is sewn) and pull-test each eye.

The horns, ears, muzzle, legs and tail are sewn on, and the fringe and tail are knotted yarn: sew every seam twice, weave ends in at least 5 cm, and knot the fringe and tail securely.

Not tested to ASTM F963 or EN 71 — do not describe finished Hamishes as “baby-safe”. For children under three, embroider the eyes with black floss instead of safety eyes.

Materials

- **Yarn A — ginger:** worsted/aran (#4), about 25 g used. Caramel, toffee or ginger gold. One 80 g / 150 m ball covers several cows and re-dos.
- **Yarn B — oat cream:** worsted/aran (#4), about 12 g. Muzzle, horns, inner ears, optional belly patch.
- **Yarn C — dark chocolate:** worsted/aran (#4), about 5 g. Hooves and nostrils.
- **Yarn D — rust (optional):** about 6 g for the scarf, or 28 cm of 12 mm tartan ribbon.
- **Hook:** 3.5 mm (US E-4) — smaller than the ball band so stuffing cannot show.
- **Eyes:** 2 x 12 mm black safety eyes, or embroider for under-threes.
- **Also:** polyester fibre fill about 30 g (buy 50 g to over-stuff the base); stitch marker, tapestry needle, pins, scissors.

Gauge & size check

11 sc x 12 rounds = 5 cm / 2 in in Yarn A.

Not critical, but loose tension lets stuffing show — drop half a hook size if your fabric is gappy. Finished size about 15 cm / 6 in sitting.

The pieces

Piece	Qty	Rounds	Finished size
Head	1	1-16	~ 70 x 67 mm, closed ball
Muzzle	1	1-8	face ~ 35 mm, rim ~ 26 mm
Body	1	1-19	~ 70 mm wide, neck open at 18
Belly patch (opt.)	1	R1-R4	flat oval, 36 sts
Legs	4	1-16	~ 67 mm, hoof + BLO ridge
Ears (inner+outer)	2+2	1-3 / 1-7	cupped forward
Horns	2	1-7	short, curved, tip-stuffed
Fringe & tail	—	—	lark's head knotted yarn

Abbreviations — US terms

MR magic ring • ch chain • sl st slip stitch • sc single crochet • hdc half double crochet • inc 2 sc in one st • dec invisible decrease • BLO back loop only • FO fasten off • (n) stitch count at round end.

Construction at a glance

- **Spiral.** work in a continuous spiral unless a round says join; mark the first stitch of every round. Leave 30–40 cm tails on every piece you will sew.
- **Invisible decrease.** insert the hook through the FRONT loops only of the next two stitches, yarn over and pull through both, then yarn over and pull through the remaining two. Every dec is worked this way — no ridge on visible rounds.
- **Back loop only (BLO).** work into the far loop only; the unused loops form a raised ridge. Hamish's hoof line is one BLO round.
- **Working around a chain.** for the belly patch, crochet into both sides of a starting chain — turning a chain into a flat oval.
- **Lark's head knot.** fold a strand in half, push the folded loop under a stitch with the hook, pull the two loose ends through the loop and cinch. Used for every fringe strand and the tail.
- **Ladder stitch.** the invisible seam: out on one side, pick up one bar on the opposite side, then one bar back, alternating, pulling snug every few stitches. The head-to-body join needs two full passes.

Three sizes, one pattern

Version	Yarn / hook	Eyes	Height
Wee Hamish	DK / #3 • 2.75 mm	8–9 mm	~ 12 cm
Classic	Worsted / #4 • 3.5 mm	12 mm	~ 15 cm
Cuddle Hamish	Bulky chenille / #5 • 5.0 mm	16–18 mm	~ 21 cm

Stitch counts stay the same; only yarn, hook and stuffing change. Yarn scales with the square of the height and stuffing with the cube — buy generously for the big chenille version.

1 · Head — worked crown down, one straight round only

One straight round (R9) is what keeps the brow flat and wide instead of egg-shaped. Close to 6 stitches at the end.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Notes
1	6 sc in MR	6	
2	inc in each st around	12	
3	[sc, inc] x 6	18	
4	[2 sc, inc] x 6	24	
5	[3 sc, inc] x 6	30	
6	[4 sc, inc] x 6	36	fringe row 3
7	[5 sc, inc] x 6	42	fringe row 2 / horns
8	[6 sc, inc] x 6	48	fringe row 1 / ears
9	sc in each st around	48	eyes at R9-R10
10	[6 sc, dec] x 6	42	
11	[5 sc, dec] x 6	36	
12	[4 sc, dec] x 6	30	stuff firmly, flatten front to back
13	[3 sc, dec] x 6	24	
14	[2 sc, dec] x 6	18	
15	[sc, dec] x 6	12	last pinch of stuffing
16	dec x 6	6	close the hole

- **Eyes & head size.** place the 12 mm eyes between Rnds 9 and 10, 7 stitches apart and a touch low on the face (7 sts ~ 32 mm, just under half the head width). Leave washers off until the muzzle is pinned. Finished head ~ 70 mm wide x 67 mm tall.

2 · Muzzle — Yarn B, make 1

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Notes
1	6 sc in MR	6	
2	inc in each st around	12	
3	[sc, inc] x 6	18	
4	[2 sc, inc] x 6	24	
5	sc in each st around	24	face at full width, 35 mm
6	sc in each st around	24	
7	sc in each st around	24	
8	[2 sc, dec] x 6	18	rim = 26 mm across

Fasten off with a 40 cm tail and stuff lightly. The muzzle FACE is about 35 mm across (the wide cream patch you see); the RIM it sews by is about 26 mm, spanning roughly six rounds of head. Pin the top edge just under the eyes at Rnd 10 and let the lower edge fall at Rnd 15–16 near the chin. Centre it, let the face sit a little wider than the eye spacing, and sew with small whip stitches, adding a whisper more stuffing before you close.

Nostrils (Yarn C): two short vertical satin stitches, 3 stitches apart, on the lower third. Mouth: one tiny horizontal stitch or a shallow V below them. LOCK THE SAFETY-EYE WASHERS NOW.

The wide cream muzzle, low-set eyes and shaggy fringe give the Highland stare.

3 · Body — worked bottom up, neck left open at 18 stitches

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Notes
1	6 sc in MR	6	
2	inc in each st around	12	
3	[sc, inc] x 6	18	
4	[2 sc, inc] x 6	24	
5	[3 sc, inc] x 6	30	
6	[4 sc, inc] x 6	36	
7	[5 sc, inc] x 6	42	
8	[6 sc, inc] x 6	48	front legs join R8-R9
9	sc in each st around	48	
10	sc in each st around	48	body at full width, 70 mm
11	sc in each st around	48	
12	sc in each st around	48	
13	sc in each st around	48	
14	[6 sc, dec] x 6	42	
15	sc in each st around	42	
16	[5 sc, dec] x 6	36	
17	[4 sc, dec] x 6	30	stuff firmly, pack the base
18	[3 sc, dec] x 6	24	
19	[2 sc, dec] x 6	18	leave neck OPEN

Fasten off with a 40 cm tail; do not close. Body is ~19 rounds (79 mm); with the head seated on the neck ring the finished sitting height is about 15 cm / 6 in.

4 • Belly patch — Yarn B, optional (flat oval around a chain)

Ch 9. R1: sc in 2nd ch, sc in next 6, 3 sc in last ch, sc in next 6, 2 sc in last loop (18). R2: inc, 6 sc, inc x3, 6 sc, inc x2 (24). R3: sc, inc, 6 sc, [sc, inc] x3, 6 sc, [sc, inc] x2 (30). R4: 2 sc, inc, 6 sc, [2 sc, inc] x3, 6 sc, [2 sc, inc] x2 (36). Sl st, FO with a long tail; sew centred on the front with the lower edge about 3 rounds up from the base. Skip it for a plain ginger front — both are correct.

5 · Legs — make 4, identical (the sit comes from where you sew them)

Sixteen rounds = a 67 mm leg.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Notes
1	6 sc in MR (Yarn C)	6	hoof
2	inc in each st around	12	
3	[sc, inc] x 6	18	
4	sc in each st around	18	
5	sc in each st around	18	
6	BLO sc around	18	change to Yarn A — ridge
7	sc in each st around	18	
8	[sc, dec] x 6	12	stuff hoof firmly
9	sc in each st around	12	
10	sc in each st around	12	
11	sc in each st around	12	
12	sc in each st around	12	
13	sc in each st around	12	upper leg light
14	[2 sc, dec] x 3	9	
15	sc in each st around	9	
16	sc in each st around	9	leave top open

Leg length — read before you sew

A 67 mm leg joins much lower than it is long, so it splays: front ~55 degrees from vertical, back ~68-70 degrees (near horizontal) — that is the low Highland sit. For a tidier upright sit, work the FRONT pair only to Rnd 10 (42 mm); leave the back pair at 16 rounds as haunches.

6 • Ears — make 2 of each layer

INNER ear — Yarn B (make 2): R1: 6 sc in MR (6). R2: [sc, inc] x 3 (9). R3: [2 sc, inc] x 3 (12).

OUTER ear — Yarn A (make 2): R1: 6 sc in MR (6). R2: [sc, inc] x 3 (9). R3: [2 sc, inc] x 3 (12). R4: sc around (12). R5: sc around (12). R6: [2 sc, dec] x 3 (9). R7: sc around (9).

Place the inner ear on the outer (cream facing you) before the outer's Rnd 4 and work Rnd 4 through both layers. Flatten, fasten off, and pinch the base with 2–3 stitches so the ear cups forward.

7 • Horns — Yarn B, make 2

R1: 4 sc in MR (4). R2: [sc, inc] x 2 (6). R3: sc around (6). R4: sc around (6). R5: [2 sc, inc] x 2 (8). R6: sc around (8). R7: sc around (8). Fasten off with a tail; stuff the tip only. Short and slightly curved — tilt each horn out and a little back when you sew.

8 · Tail & 9 · the fringe — Yarn A, knotted yarn

Tail: cut 6 strands, each 22 cm / 8.5 in. Fold the bundle in half and attach with a lark's head at the centre-back just above the last increase round: pull the folded loop through a stitch, then the tails through the loop. Folding gives 12 hanging ends; divide into 3 groups of 4, braid 4 cm, knot firmly and trim into a small tassel.

Fringe: attach AFTER the horns and ears so you can part the hair around them. Cut 43 strands, each 14 cm / 5.5 in (swap 6 for Yarn C for depth; cut a 44th as a spare). Attach with lark's head knots in a horseshoe from one ear, across the brow, to the other, filling three rows: every stitch on Rnd 8 (front row, ~24 knots), then every other stitch on Rnds 7 and 6 — about $24 + 10 + 9 = 43$ knots. Tousle, then trim so the fringe grazes the eyes and breaks into uneven points. Highland hair is weather-beaten, not a salon fringe.

10 · Optional tartan scarf — Yarn D

Ch 61. Row 1: hdc in 2nd ch from hook and across (60). Row 2: ch 1, turn, hdc across (60). Fasten off; add a 3-strand tassel at each end or weave a second colour as a slip-stitch stripe to hint at tartan, then tie loosely under the muzzle. Ribbon shortcut: 28 cm of 12 mm rust tartan ribbon, knotted once.

Assembly — work in this order

- **1 Muzzle & face:** sewn and washers locked (section 2).
- **2 Horns:** between Rnds 5 and 7, 6 stitches apart, angled out and slightly back.
- **3 Ears:** just outside and below each horn, centred on Rnds 8–9, cupped forward.
- **4 Fringe:** attach and trim (section 9), parting around horns and ears.
- **5 Head to body:** closed head on the open 18-st neck ring (Rnd 19). Ball-on-ring join — pack the neck firmly, ladder-stitch around TWICE, tilt the muzzle slightly down.
- **6 Back legs:** lower sides across Rnds 3–6, almost on the base, splayed near horizontal.
- **7 Front legs:** across Rnds 8–9, about 8 sts apart, angled forward ~55 degrees.
- **8 Belly patch:** only if you made it.
- **9 Tail & scarf:** attach the tassel tail, tie the scarf, weave in every end and fluff the fringe.

Before you sew — lay every component out and check

1 head (closed at R16) • 1 muzzle • 1 body (open neck ring) • 1 belly patch (optional) • 4 legs (hooves forward) • 2 outer + 2 inner ears • 2 horns • 1 tassel tail • 1 fringe • 1 scarf.

Colorways

● Ginger ● Caramel ● Highland black ● Cream ● Roan red

Troubleshooting

- **He will not sit.** restuff the body base firmly and sew the back legs lower and wider — closer to horizontal than you think.
- **Front hooves float.** sewn too high — they belong on Rnds 8–9, not under the neck. If they still float, the legs are too long: work the front pair to Rnd 10.
- **Stuffing shows.** drop half a hook size, or hold a matching thread with the yarn on visible rounds.
- **Face looks blank.** the eyes are too high. Low eyes plus a wide muzzle is the Highland stare.
- **Fringe is sparse.** add a fourth row behind the horns and mix in one darker shade.
- **Horns flop.** under-stuffed at the tip, or sewn only at the edge — stitch a full round into the head fabric.
- **Head tips forward.** the neck ring grips the head only about 8 mm up. Pack the neck before closing and make the second ladder-stitch pass tight.

Why this pattern works — validation summary

Every stitch count in this pattern was checked with deterministic math (Crochet Pattern Checker): round-by-round production vs. consumption, stated counts, and every size claim against the stated gauge.

Check	Result
Head Rnds 1–16: 6 → 48 → 6, stated counts match	✓ verified
Muzzle 24 → 18: face 34.8 mm / rim 26.1 mm at gauge	✓ verified
Body Rnds 1–19: 6 → 48 → 18 (open neck ring)	✓ verified
Belly patch oval 18 → 24 → 30 → 36	✓ verified
Legs: 18 → 12 → 9 ladder; 16 rnds = 67 mm	✓ verified
Head 48 sts ≈ 69.5 mm wide; 16 rnds ≈ 66.7 mm tall	✓ verified
Body 19 rnds ≈ 79 mm; fringe 24+10+9 = 43 knots	✓ verified

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SAFETY REMINDER

This pattern has not been tested to a toy-safety standard (ASTM F963 / EN 71) and uses 12 mm safety eyes and knotted yarn fringe. Finished items made for sale must be assessed by the seller against local toy-safety laws; for young children, embroider the eyes and secure every seam and knot.

Happy crocheting! Tag your makes with #NovalityStore and #HamishTheHighlandCow — thank you for supporting an independent pattern designer.

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